# Cloning animals – model discussion



Read the model discussion below and then complete the tasks on the next page.

The Tasmanian tiger, ***thylacine***, is a marsupial carnivore that used to live in Tasmania. European settlers believed this animal to be dangerous to them and their farm animals and so started hunting it down. The last thylacine died in captivity in 1936. Some scientists want to clone a thylacine and reintroduce it to Tasmania, but there are arguments against as well as in favour of this issue.

Thylacines were native animals of Tasmania. It was only because European settlers feared them that they were exterminated. Had the European people not murdered this indigenous marsupial, the thylacine would still be living in Tasmania today. Reintroducing cloned Tasmanian tigers would only make right the wrong done by people of the past.

Cloning technology for animals exists. Scientists know how to clone animals and have cloned many already: sheep, cows, goats, cats and mice are some examples. Although an extinct animal has not been cloned, with some more research scientists could do that too. There is no scientific technology standing in the way of cloning the Tasmanian tiger.

On the other hand, the Tasmanian tiger lived in Tasmania more than one hundred years ago. Since then, the large island has changed – there is less bushland, and more farms and towns. It is no longer the same Tasmania. Sending an extinct animal into today's Tasmania would be as thoughtless as expecting a polar bear to survive in the jungle.

When scientists clone animals, many cells with a new nucleus never develop into offspring, or the offspring may be malformed. There is a tremendous amount of tragic wastage during cloning. It is also very expensive. Even if a stem cell is filled with a thylacine nucleus, there are many questions that still need to be answered: Which animal would the stem cell come from? Which animal would carry the new cells and give birth to the infant Tasmanian tiger? Which animal would nourish the growing offspring? Until these issues have been resolved satisfactorily, cloning of the extinct thylacine should not be attempted.

In conclusion, the Tasmanian tiger should not be cloned. It is too expensive and wasteful and a positive outcome cannot be guaranteed. It is also likely that a reintroduced thylacine would die out again, because too much of Tasmania has changed significantly during the last century. Unfortunately, the Tasmanian tiger has become extinct and it should remain so.

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**7b**

**1** The discussion text type on the previous page contains four sections: ***Introduction, Arguments for, Arguments against, Conclusion***. Draw a large square bracket in the left margin to indicate each section, and label it.

**2** Often a paragraph includes key words near the start to describe what it is about. Double underline the key words in each paragraph.

**3** In the right margin, briefly summarise the main content of each paragraph.

**4** State the purpose of this discussion.

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**5** The arguments in a discussion are usually backed up with facts. Scientific words can highlight these. Circle at least five scientific words in the arguments section.

**6** Although discussions contain many facts, they also use emotive language that exaggerates and appeals to your feelings. One example of emotive language is 'murdered'. Underline at least five other examples.

**7** Select one topic from the list below and write a discussion about it. Start by planning useful points for each paragraph. You may need to research the topic first. In the scaffold at the bottom of the page, note useful points you could include for each paragraph. Then in your workbook write your discussion in six paragraphs.

### Topics

**a** In the USA, people can pay $50 000 to have their favourite dead cat cloned. Is that wise?

**b** A farmer wants her ageing prize ram cloned so that she can continue to use it for breeding.

**c** Phar Lap was a very fast Australian racehorse and he died in 1932. He should be cloned so he can win horse races again.

**d** A cow producing unusually large amounts of milk is going to be cloned 12 times to replace a large but old cow herd.

**e** More mice should be cloned so that scientists can learn more about cloning techniques.

### Discussion scaffold

| 1. Introduction | 2. First argument for | 3. Second argument for |
|---|---|---|
| **4. First argument against** | **5. Second argument against** | **6. Conclusion and recommendation** |


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